

Who Should the Self-Driving Car Save?



Analysis of "The Moral Machine experiment" (Awad et al., 2018)



Context

Autonomous vehicles are slowly becoming a reality on public roads and even with perfect technology, some accidents cannot be avoided, making the programming of life-or-death decisions necessary.

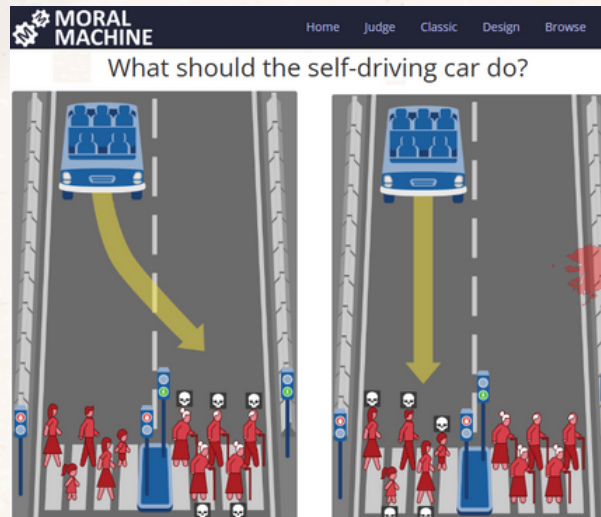
Problem

The main problem is the lack of a universal moral consensus, creating a dilemma for engineers.



Research Method

To capture diverse ethical preferences, the authors deployed a viral online platform called the "[Moral Machine](#)".



It crowdsourced over 40 million decisions from 2.3 million participants worldwide by asking them to judge randomized scenarios similar to the "trolley problem".

Main Findings

While "universals" exist, such as preferring to spare humans over animals or sparing more lives (5 vs 1), the strength of these preferences varies wildly by region. Three distinct "Moral Clusters" were identified:

Western

Bias for Inaction: Westerners prefer not to swerve, adhering to the principle that active intervening to cause a small harm is worse than allowing a bigger harm to happen naturally.

Eastern

Weaker preference for sparing the young over older humans, possibly because these cultures place a much higher value on respecting the elderly.

Southern

Higher preference for sparing Females and people of High Status (Doctors or Athletes over homeless people, in this case), a trend that is linked to the income inequality found in these nations.